

Episode 80: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative! *Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes (Part 1)

The TV broadcast of *GeGeGe no Kitaro* (5th series) will end at the end of March. The final episode will be exactly episode 100.

100 episodes.

I remembered the producer saying that the *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!* that I was involved in making last year would "connect to an episode around the 100th episode of the series." What will they do with the remaining "47 Yokai Warriors" (sweat)? Hmm... Though it's not my concern, it's somewhat bothering me these days.

Now then.

Casshern Sins (キャシャーンス *Sins*), currently airing magnificently in late-night slots on MBS and other stations - its DVD & Blu-Ray release has finally begun. For this work where I participated as colour design (色彩設計), "Everyone please buy them! Especially the Blu-Ray versions!" So for the next four weeks, I'll be delivering "*Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes"!

First this week, episodes 1-6 included in BOX 1.

I joined *Casshern Sins* in late summer 2007. Actually, at that point the production site was working toward "broadcast start April 2008!" Just six months later, aiming for broadcast start, there was talk of "somehow getting 4-5 episodes in stock."

However, the situation changed. Before we knew it, the "April 2008" broadcast start disappeared and became "Autumn 2008!"

"Well, somehow we'll get 12-13 episodes in stock..." I often discussed this with the production producer, but... it's not so easy to build up stock in today's TV anime production situation. As much time as you have, you end up using it all until the last minute - that's the way of the world (laughs). Ha ha ha (laughs).

So ultimately, it ended up being a last-minute start after all (laughs).

Between Director Yamauchi (山内監督) and me, from some point it had become an implicit understanding, our normal way of working, that "everything would be decided scene by scene with art board matching." *Casshern Sins* uses this method too.

Well, for various convenience reasons (like animation reference and promotional materials), I made basic normal character colour samples and colour direction, but those were just samples - they would almost never appear as-is on the actual screens.

I attend art board commission meetings with the art staff and listen to the director explain the scene atmosphere. Then I receive the art boards completed by the art staff and approved by the director, and matching those boards, I compose character colour schemes while imagining the performance flow. Then I have the episode director check those colour samples + art board combinations and get approval, using that as a "blueprint" to request individual cuts from the colour direction staff assigned to each episode.

That's the flow for individual episodes. Furthermore, I think about the colour composition, flow, and balance throughout the entire series. How to construct the character colour world throughout all 24 episodes - I consider this an important job in series colour design.

When entering episode 1, scripts for quite a few episodes were ready except for the latter half to climax, so I could grasp the overall picture and enter design after thinking about the composition myself.

Episode 1: "In a World Coming to an End"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Colour Direction: Kunioto Kunio

In episode 1, the story begins with absolutely no explanation. Casshern fights furiously, then a mysterious little girl appears and they interact, he saves her from crisis, and finally an even more mysterious woman appears and picks a fight with Casshern. Such is episode 1 (laughs).

I thought if we could somehow show "this kind of world" feeling in about the first 3 episodes, that would be good. So in episode 1, I just worked steadily on creating screens matched to backgrounds.

This is what kind of visual and what kind of taste this work has. It's fine if viewers end up feeling "what? what?" after watching. That's episode 1.

Being episode 1 above all, both art and colour were initially working by feel. Working with atmosphere emphasis, it ended up with a nice heavy finish, but...

Actually this work has "bleeding" processing added via photography work throughout. This is tricky (laughs). When photography "bleeding" is applied to the screen, overall contrast becomes stronger. Especially dark parts are emphasised, creating dramatically dark screens.

Background and cel matching was decided based on HD master monitor standards, so in the "raw" state it had quite a finished, settled balance. When "bleeding" was applied on top of that, watching the all-rush, everyone said "Oh no... dark, or rather black (sweat)."

We certainly couldn't remake it (←didn't want to (laughs)), so we pushed through saying "Well, it'll be fine! Surely... probably (sweat)" (burst).

So the first half of episode 1 ended up with the darkest screen throughout the series (laughs).

However, from the latter half when the large robot appears, we're using "normal" colour direction. Since it was episode 1, I somehow wanted to end episode 1 with "normal" colour tone. The backgrounds happened to be bright scenes too, so they're raw normal colours.

Episode 2: "The World is Full of Doomsday Voices"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Colour Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Episode 2 explains "Actually this world has been hit by something called 'ruin.'" In episode 2, I'm doing something like a miniature, compressed version of the overall colour design composition for the entire *Casshern Sins* series.

Basically, the first half does scene-by-scene decisions matched to backgrounds, the middle creates scenes with special colour usage matched to what the characters are talking about, and the latter half adds mysterious colour tones to character shadow colours riding on the characters' emotional ups and downs. This flow is actually what I was trying to do throughout the entire series.

Episode 2's climax, where Casshern massacres the community's civilian robots in madness mode, and the buildup of cuts and colour tones leading to that point - I'm quite proud of how well that turned out! (laughs)

The special colouring used in this madness mode, adding mysterious colours to shadow colours, I mostly sealed away until the latter half of the series, especially until Luna appears.

Episodes 1 and 2 anyway were made using plenty of time. Naturally the animation frame count also reached wonderful heights (laughs). The quality is supreme. But the production producer's face was blue (laughs).

Episode 3: "At the End of Suffering"

Script: Yamato-ya Akira / Storyboard & Direction: Minatsu Tatsuya / Animation Director: Nishii Terumi / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Episode 3: "Actually, humans are still barely surviving too."

Casshern still can't grasp the situation well. Moreover, guilt from "doing something terrible (sweat)" in the previous episode weighs on him. Then comes a certain reconciliation or understanding with Friender.

Series composition that doesn't follow the main plot too much but sprinkles episodic complete stories - but this is important, building up the characters' emotional movements and flow through such stories.

Episode 3 doesn't do anything particularly special colour-wise, just working carefully and steadily to create the distance, atmosphere, and feeling between Casshern and Akoz.

Episode 3's colour direction was by Akimoto Yuki-san. She and Kohinata Tomoko-san, who appears from episode 5 onward, are two people we always rely on for Toei (東映) productions. Since I could sync up with these two, I asked their company president "Please!" and had them participate.

As a result, they each handled colour direction for 1/3 of all 24 episodes, and two endings completely from colour design, respectively. My gratitude! So grateful!

Episode 4: "Angel of Destruction"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Colour Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Somehow a flow developed where "episodes directed by the director have Tsujita-san also handle colour direction," so I also handled colour direction for episode 4.

Episode 4 is also a "this is the world Casshern exists in" type story. For this story, I created scene colours with "beauty" as the theme.

In *Casshern Sins*, I basically design character colours from scratch with nothing to start from. While Casshern, Friender, and Braiking Boss are based on the "original work" colours, everything else was my original... Though I haven't actually watched the "original work" (laughs). The flow was: receive character line art from Umakoshi-san → I create colours first → show to director and Umakoshi-san and get approval.

For this story's guest character Sophita, from when I first received the character design, I had somehow decided on "brown skin." I wonder why? I heard later that the director apparently had a somewhat "pale" image.

I was surprised when I heard Sophita's voice in the all-rush. It was Akitani Tomoko-san, the voice of Hazuki-chan from *Ojamajo Doremi* (おジャ魔女どれみ). And the brown-skinned Sophita was just perfect for that voice! This must also be Yamauchi magic (laughs).

Just when episode 4's production peak coincided with the final push of *Dragon Ball Z* production for Shueisha Jump Tours, I was fighting a 24-hour system - Toei (東映)

during the day, Madhouse (マッドハウス) at night, no time to sleep. On top of that, the *Casshern Sins* opening overlapped... Ah, good memories (distant gaze).

Oh yes, the animation rule that "bangs don't show through in *Casshern Sins*!" was established starting from this episode. Until then it was all over the place - sometimes transparent, sometimes not. Actually there are several cuts in this episode we couldn't fix completely (laughs).

Episode 5: "The Man Who Killed the Sun Named Moon"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard: Ohira Naoki / Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

"Stalker Ryuze" and Casshern constantly worrying. The 'Luna murder' avant-title that appears for several cuts at the beginning of each main episode, connected flashback scenes of Lyuze and Casshern appear, revealing why Ryuze is pursuing Casshern. And finally "Black Casshern" Dio appears. The story that finally starts moving toward the main plot... maybe? Episode 5.

This story also had colour design steadily matched scene by scene. Episode 5 had the fewest scene colour changes of any episode.

The "Luna murder" scene shown in the avant-title was created with red-purple as the image colour, but what about the area before that, where she confronts Lyuze? After much thought, I made it "normally" darkish, but hmm, maybe I should have added one more touch?

Episodes 5 and 6 are connected stories. And this following episode 6 was actually made almost parallel with episode 1 schedule-wise. So I asked Kohinata-san, who handled episode 6's colour direction, to also do episode 5 later. Actually, the evening scene in the B-part uses exactly what was created for episode 6.

Episode 6: "Reunion With Destiny"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard & Direction: Ito Naoyuki / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

So episode 6, made almost parallel with episode 1. Naturally, the screen is dark (laughs). But since it's almost all evening throughout, the bright parts look quite bright.

Also, the bangs are totally transparent (laughs). This was also because it was animation from before the rule was established.

The key point of episode 6 is definitely Dio. This Dio was quite a difficult "troublemaker."

Because Dio basically has a "black" bodysuit. A black suit with bright highlight-like parts - that kind of design. However, that area was unorganised when animation progressed, and I overthought it and made him too "black." Maybe I should have made him a bit brighter, calling in the evening light around him to reflect back? > Dio

However, in terms of the balance of mysteriousness, this level of darkness was totally OK for me. I thought it was fine if the dark parts got crushed, and since the master was made based on digital terrestrial and HD screens, it looked properly visible on the master monitor so it was good! But the world was still mainly analogue viewing, so voices came from various directions saying "It's too dark to see!" (laughs).

So there was that, and from the point of the overall "flow" of the series and colour design composition, episodes after this gradually have more bright screens.

Even so, I earnestly think I want people to watch on digital terrestrial rather than analogue terrestrial broadcast, and on Blu-Ray rather than regular DVD (laughs).

(09.02.24)